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12 Tips for Managing Conflict at Work

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If you've struggled with managing conflict at work — whether that entailed arguing too much, giving in too easily, acting passive aggressively, or avoiding conflict entirely — know that your history with conflict management can be a learning experience that leads to productive work relations in your future. With the right skills at your disposal, you'll spend less energy on needless drama so you can invest more energy into meaningful work.

To help you become better at managing work conflict, we've curated advice from four popular LinkedIn Learning courses on the topic. While the goal of

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remember. The courses are:

- **Having Difficult Conversations** with **Marlene Chism**, author of *Stop Workplace Drama* and *No-Drama Leadership*.
- **Conflict Resolution Foundations** with leadership coach and “career story sleuth” **Lisa Gates**.
- **Why Conflict is Necessary and How to Manage It** with host **Morra Aarons-Mele**, author of *The Anxious Achiever*. In this episode, Aarons-Mele interviews workplace expert and author of *Getting Along*, **Amy Gallo**.
- **Navigating Fundamental Disagreements** with **Alyssa Lowery**, a researcher and professor of philosophy at Longwood University.

We'll start with perspective because having the right mindset is a fundamental aspect of making work conflict more productive. We'll then highlight a few helpful exercises that can help you prepare for difficult conversations. Finally, we'll touch on some dos and don'ts for managing work conflict. Let's dig in:

How to think about managing work conflict: Perspective and mindset

Understand that you can't, and probably shouldn't, completely avoid work conflict.

Conflict isn't just a normal part of work, says Marlene Chism. It's also a necessary part of professional growth. “If you aren't having some conflict, it probably means you aren't really growing,” she says.

Still, that doesn't mean we need to accept conflict as the norm. By acquiring the right mindset and the right conflict management skills, we can use

Amy Gallo agrees, saying that conflict is something we don't engage in enough, at least not in a healthy way. Rather than fearing conflict, Gallo recommends viewing it more as an opportunity.

"In fact, if we avoid it completely, which many people try to do, we're not going to get what we need," Gallo says. "We think by avoiding conflict, we're preserving the harmony between us, the relationship between us or another person. And that might be the case some of the time, but ultimately, I think of it as an act of love or respect to say the things that are hard to say."

Stop thinking about work conflict in terms of winning and losing.

Gallo acknowledges that one of the mental shifts she's had to make is to stop thinking that there's a winner and a loser, or that one person is right and the other person is wrong.

"It's not just you and me," she says, "but there's this third entity, which is the question at hand, the business issue we need to solve, the decision that needs to be made. And ultimately, we both want what's best for that."

Gallo points to the example of how going through tough times with someone and reaching a positive resolution will oftentimes make the relationship stronger. Even if she was wrong, she says, the fact that a good decision was made ultimately means it's a win for everyone.

The key here is to stop seeing the conflict as opposite sides engaged in battle, even though "this notion of conflict isn't entirely wrong," Chism says.

"If we look at the definition of conflict," she continues, "we read that it's a serious disagreement or an argument, typically long-lasting. No wonder most of us struggle with conflict. Who in their right mind would volunteer for a long-lasting argument or disagreement? That doesn't sound like much fun, but I want to challenge that."

improve our chances of achieving our mission — we'll address complicated situations sooner, and with greater ease.

Preparing to deal with work conflict

Prepare to have your emotions triggered.

Most of us prepare for hard conversations or conflict with good intentions. Problems arise, however, when someone or something triggers our emotions. Those emotions then get in the way and we handle the situation a lot more poorly than we had planned.

What's happening, Gallo explains, is your prefrontal cortex is being trumped by your amygdala, a phenomenon emotional intelligence experts call the “**amygdala hijack**.”

“You're just simply not thinking rationally,” Gallo says. “You're reacting to the situation.”

Gallo says that our original plans often veer off course, even for people like her who teach conflict management. “But you can come back to it and readdress it,” she says. “Try to come to a different resolution and a different process that feels true to who you are, rather than, ‘Oh gosh, I lost it. I didn't stick to what I really intended.’”

These are difficult situations. If you're expecting perfection, you may be putting too much pressure on yourself. Remember, most of the time you can recover from a conflict that went badly.

Gallo gives herself a few days, and if the conflict is still top of mind, she'll revisit it. “I will come back and say, ‘You know what? Can we readdress that? I actually am not happy with where that ended up,’” she says. “Or, ‘I'm not happy with how I behaved in that conversation. I'd love to talk about it.’”

Separate fact from fiction.

“In a conflict, there are two things happening,” says Lisa Gates. “One is what actually happened, and two is how people interpret what happened.”

Gates says it’s not the facts, but the stories we tell ourselves about the facts that get us into trouble. Usually it’s not really about what the other person did or said, but how those words or actions made us feel.

“The truth is, nobody can make you feel what you feel. You make you feel what you feel. Take that in,” Gates says. “That isn’t to say your feelings shouldn’t be felt, but very often our unexamined feelings lead us into unproductive behaviors.”

Gates offers up five questions to examine your stories and feelings more closely. Thinking through the following questions should make it easier to distinguish fact from fiction:

1. How are you behaving in regards to the issue? Are you stewing on it? Being sarcastic? Reacting with anger? Blaming the other person?
2. What stories are you telling yourself to justify your behavior? Gates says the stories we tell ourselves often begin with phrases like, “I never,” or “I always,” or “you never,” or, “you always.”
3. What feelings do those stories generate?
4. What might also be true? Asking this question is about finding new ways to view a conflict. Gates encourages you to see if you can come up with alternate versions that create some wiggle room to feel empathy toward the other person.
5. How can you take responsibility for your part in the conflict? Before you attempt to resolve a conflict, you need to take responsibility for

responsibility for your contributions to the conflict.

“The fact from fiction exercise is not easy stuff,” Gates says. “But if you take the time to noodle through your thoughts and feelings and stories, you’ll give yourself the clarity you need to find your way back to cooperation and workability.”

Dealing with work conflict: What to avoid

Don’t initiate a conversation when you’re emotional.

Never initiate a conversation when you’re overly emotional, Chism says. “It’s okay to feel emotions,” she adds. “Your emotions tell you that a conversation needs to happen. But you’ve got to time it right.”

The right time, according to Chism, is once you’ve calmed down. Waiting until then will put you in a much better position to initiate a difficult conversation. Furthermore, you’ll also give yourself extra time to think about the result you desire.

Gallo recommends the advice a therapist once gave her when she was ruminating over a relationship issue. The therapist said that when you have an idea that you think will solve the conflict, write it down. Then put it away for 24 hours before you come back to it. It’s like sleeping on a big decision — the extra time should allow for some added clarity and perspective.

But don’t wait too long to address conflict either.

Gallo references a concept called **conflict debt** to encourage proactive conflict management. The premise of conflict debt is that when teams avoid having difficult conversations, they go into debt, and that debt eventually commands a high-interest payment. As difficult conversations get further delayed, they only become harder to address, and the debt continues to accrue until it ultimately becomes unmanageable.

relationship, and even more confidence.”

That’s why investing in conflict management skills is so important — because it makes navigating relationships, work culture, and even the world in general a little bit easier. Gallo points out that if you struggle with anxiety, developing your conflict management skills can help you control your nervousness in more situations.

Don’t have difficult conversations digitally.

“I realize that writing can be a lot easier than talking when we’re upset,” says Chism. “The urge can be pretty strong to hide behind an email when emotions are hot.”

Resist that urge, advises Chism. If you feel like writing, that’s okay. In fact, writing or journaling about your emotions may help you sort through them and achieve some mental clarity. But again, you must resist the urge to send that email, text, or chat, no matter how thoughtful or logical your message seems.

In fact, Chism says that digital communication is never appropriate for conversations that involve performance issues, criticizing others, or defending yourself. “And if someone triggers you with their email, don’t take the bait,” she warns. “Don’t forward the email to others, and don’t seek other opinions, and don’t defend yourself. Just don’t respond. Ask for a face-to-face meeting. If that’s not possible, ask for a phone meeting.”

Dealing with conflict: Helpful strategies

Change your own pattern first.

When conflict is ongoing, it’s common for one person to “know” in advance how the other person will react. “What this really means is the two of us have a past, and because of that past history, we engage in certain patterns,” says

your own patterns.”

As an example, Chism cites a boss who had a pattern of raising his voice. As a result, she had a pattern of avoiding him. If both of these patterns continued, it would be impossible to engage in a difficult conversation. Chism knew that one of the patterns needed to change, and it would be up to her.

So, the next time her boss yelled, she decided to just listen, and then she stayed silent for a few seconds. She still felt frustrated, but she was willing to feel that frustration if it could change the pattern, which it did. He actually listened, and that taught Chism a crucial lesson: Sometimes when we change our own pattern, the other person will change theirs as well.

Ask diagnostic questions.

Learning the art of asking diagnostic questions — open-ended questions beginning with who, what, when, where, how, and why — is by far the most important practice in conflict resolution, says Gates. Yet most people fail to use diagnostic questions, perhaps because they don’t know their power to improve outcomes.

The purpose of asking diagnostic questions, she says, is to discover where you’re likely to encounter resistance, or as she puts it, “where the nos are buried.” She also admits that shifting from **close-ended questions** to diagnostic questions can take some practice. “When you notice you’re about to ask a close-ended question, pause,” she advises, “then restart with a ‘what’ or a ‘how,’ and finish your sentence.”

Use this magic phrase to test for resistance.

Chism defines resistance as any form of negativity or non-acceptance; an unwillingness to move forward. For example, here are a few examples she gives of how people resist during a difficult conversation:

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- This isn't fair.
 - I don't have enough time to do what you want.
 - What you're asking for isn't possible.
 - I've already tried that.

“What do all of these phrases have in common?” asks Chism. “A lack of willingness. Where there's a lack of willingness, there's stagnation. And nothing happens without willingness; it's the fulcrum point of change.”

As such, you should expect a lack of willingness when you start a difficult conversation. After all, she says, if you're sharing bad news or asking someone to change, that comes with discomfort — which also comes with resistance and often leads to non-productive conversations.

But according to Chism, there's a magic phrase you can use to test for resistance: “Would you be willing?” This question implies that the other person has a choice in the matter, but what you're doing is testing for their resistance. How willing are they to agree to your request?”

For example, if you hear, “It wasn't my fault,” you could respond with, “That may be true, it's not all your fault. Would you be willing to apologize anyway?” And you may hear, “But I already know what he's going to say, so there's no need.” You could then respond with, “You may be right, but would you still be willing even though he may say exactly what you think?”

“Notice the technique here. You're not resisting their resistance,” Chism says. “You aren't getting distracted. You simply stay focused on the first question you asked.”

Sideline your ego, yet give yourself credit.

others, and from finding common ground.

And If you're trying your best to be proactive and remain thoughtful as you navigate conflict, acknowledge that. "These are some of the most difficult things that we navigate as people," she says. "And they're difficult on a social scale, they're difficult on a political scale, and they're really difficult interpersonally. So give yourself some credit."

If you've been disappointed by how you've managed conflict at work, remember that it's OK to learn some hard lessons before you get the hang of it. By adopting the right mindset, knowing what to avoid, and practicing helpful strategies, you too can vastly improve your conflict management skills.

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